

Recollections

Selections from Chapter II (1861–1874)

The Student Years: Teachers, Kierkegaard, Faith and Knowledge

Erindringer

Harald Høffding

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Selected passages from Chapter II, in which Høffding gives an account of his education, of the philosophers who taught him, and of the ideas he carried away from them. The section titles are not Høffding's own but have been supplied for this selection. Omissions within a section are marked [...]; more has been omitted between the sections.

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The University: Rasmus Nielsen and Sibbern

When as a young student I walked up the university stairs, it was not the first time I had gone to lectures at the University. During my last years at school I attended, for several semesters, Carsten Hauch's lectures on aesthetics. One semester he lectured on the folk ballads, another on Ewald's *Adam og Eva*, a third on a tragedy of Shakespeare's. His investigations did not go very deep, but when he became enthusiastic he could say excellent things, and his whole figure was then as though transfigured, the noble upper part of his face carrying off the victory over the somewhat drooping lower part. I preserve a vivid recollection of the mood of those lectures. — In my last year at school I also attended the lectures of Fog, later a bishop, on the study of theology. They did not prove very orienting for me as a theologian in the making. I remember only one image, meant to make vivid the coldness of rigorous science as against the warmth of faith: Athena is a lofty and noble goddess, but she did not spring from any mother's womb and has suckled no mother's breast. That image pursued me for a long while, until I discovered that it did not fit; for rigorous science is itself an expression of the human spirit, conceived and nourished by it. It has its mother in a human need which is bound up with what is innermost in personality. But it cost a great deal of labour before I could see the matter in this way. For the time being, philosophy and theology stood as two poles between which I felt myself stretched. Neither of them could I let go; but how were they to subsist together! Must there not, in the end, be some single expression here for the life of personality? —

It was Rasmus Nielsen and Sibbern who became my first teachers in philosophy. Rasmus Nielsen stood at that time at his height. He was still searching, taken with Kierkegaard and absorbed in mathematical and scientific studies, striving to find a path by which these different worlds of thought might be united. His propaedeutic lectures consisted, in my year, partly of a going-through of Kierkegaard's *Stadier* [Stages on Life's Way], on the basis of a small selection he had had printed, and partly of a short outline of the theory of knowledge. He spoke with life and force, often with wit and spirit, and I owe these lectures an extraordinary amount. They set a mass of thoughts stirring in me which until then had not moved at all. Yet it went with that course as it so often went with his books: the design was too large and comprehensive, or else he worked out the first parts of it at such length that there was not time enough left for the later ones. Of the *Stadier* he thus managed to go through only the first, the "aesthetic" stage. At every possible opportunity he polemicised against theology as a science, drawing a sharp distinction between faith and theology. This polemic at first provoked my contradiction.

I had come with great expectations of what the study of theology was to bring me; I hoped that the isolation in which the religious had hitherto stood within my inner life would, with theology's help, give way to a harmony between the different spheres. I hoped to be led into a union of the life of thought and the life of feeling, such that they supplemented one another; I hoped that Athena and the Madonna might be made one. In a diary I kept during my first years as a student I accordingly complained bitterly of those who would not acknowledge that there is such a thing as a Christian science. — It was soon to be otherwise.

While Rasmus Nielsen lectured on philosophical propaedeutics, Sibbern lectured on psychology and logic. (The philosophical course laid claim in those days to ten hours a week. That was perhaps too much. But people have gone too far in restricting it to four hours, even though a good deal can now be accomplished in that time by the use of printed texts. In my opinion six hours would be right.) The reason propaedeutics was separated from psychology and logic was that it was meant above all to give the theory of knowledge, or a general doctrine of science. Rasmus Nielsen, for that matter, gave a great deal besides the theory of knowledge under the heading of propaedeutics — in my year, for instance, the survey of the Kierkegaardian stages. There was a third professor, Hans Brøchner; he doubled alternately for Sibbern and for Nielsen, and in my year he lectured on Sibbern's subjects. I had chosen Sibbern, since I wished to hear him before he retired, and since I expected much of the author of *Gabrielis*. He was then seventy-seven. It proved a disappointment. There came, to be sure, occasional flashes of genius, fine thoughts and precious remarks; but his delivery was flat and mechanical, and his dulled senses let him neither hear how he himself rattled his keys while he spoke, nor notice the restlessness and chatter of his listeners. His naivety and oddity could be delicious — as when he named his own *Gabrielis* among “good poetic works”, or when he explained to us at length why the four clocks of the Church of Our Lady did not keep the same time. But when, because he was too warm at the lectern, he took off first his skullcap and then, when that did not help, his wig, one could not demand that young people should take it with reverence. He had outlived himself as a teacher, though his inner life still stirred with freshness. His books were heavy going to learn from, the more so as he preferred to have his own words given back to him. — Only much later, when I had myself become independent in philosophy, did I learn properly to appreciate him, and it has been a great joy to me to bring forward his memory and to characterise him,¹ and to help make his thoughts known abroad as well.

¹See *Mindre Arbejder*, First Series, and *Danske Filosofer*.

In my first year as a student I also began my theological studies, especially exegesis and church history. Exegetical study is probably what has been of most use to me within theology. It accustomed one to analysis of what one read, to precise and searching understanding, and it gave occasion for interesting comparisons among the New Testament writers. And to become at home in so great a work of the spirit as the New Testament, to be able to range through it in every direction and to feel the connection of the thoughts with the linguistic form, was already a great gain; and it is above all this that has made me never regret having studied theology, however far I have travelled from theological ways of thinking. To be sure, the diffuse German commentaries we studied were no pleasure to get sense out of. One ploughed through a whole series of interpretations which in the author's eyes were mistaken, and at last arrived at the author's own reading, which was of course the highest wisdom. There was a pedantry in this which could give one a distaste for the study. And when one reflected properly that the words which were the object of all this learning were meant to place their readers before life's greatest question, the question of spiritual life or spiritual death, one could often be indignant at the whole manner of treatment — especially just after reading a book like Kierkegaard's *Til Selvprøvelse* [For Self-Examination]. Several times I have flung the commentaries across the floor — but afterwards I went and picked them up again. I did, after all, want to finish what I had begun. —

Kierkegaard and the Dark Years

There now came a heavy and dark time in my inner life as well. I immersed myself in Kierkegaard's writings, and after a hard struggle I had to grant him that he was right in his conception of Christianity. Christianity no longer stood as the mild, consoling way of truth which could take up into itself all human ways of living — family life, art, science, the life of society — and lead them towards their completion. The idyll was blown apart. The ideal of the world beyond came to stand in its whole unconditional severity. Only one thing was, in the literal sense of the word, needful: to enter into relation with the great paradox, the wonder of the becoming-man of God, which made everything human turn pale and set only one task, that of giving up everything in order to have a share in the divine powers which, at a single place in the world and at a single point in time, had broken through the connectedness of nature and of human life and let the light of eternity shine into the darkness. Sayings in the New Testament which I had hitherto pushed aside, or interpreted mildly and harmonisingly, now came to stand in

their whole and absolute ideality. It was not Christianity's meaning to complete what human culture had begun, but to break it off and to leave all human relations standing as matters of indifference, in so far as they were not hindrances to reaching the great goal. It fell from my eyes like scales when I now took up the New Testament afresh. And it stood before me that what was proclaimed there was the highest. I cannot point to any definite moment of conversion. It was after hard resistance that I gave up the harmonious and idyllic faith of my early youth. That Christianity was, and would be, consolation, the eternal consolation, was true; but this consolation was tied to one condition: full surrender to the one thing needful, full renunciation of life's human ends. It was really only now that I discovered that neither art nor science nor civic activity is mentioned in the New Testament, and that marriage is warned against in severe terms. It was Christian ethics that now showed itself to me in a wholly new light. With dogmatics there was for the time being nothing the matter.

How was life now to be led, once the ideal had shown itself to lie higher than I had thought? The time that now came brought me, it is true, moments of heartfelt enthusiasm, but above all it brought me doubt, unrest and homelessness. I did not know what to do. The master, the prophet, had departed, after saying that the Christianity of the New Testament did not exist — if indeed it had existed at all beyond the very earliest time. It was in vain to speculate about how he would have positioned himself had he not been carried off so early. And besides, he had himself taught me that each single individual must solve the problem of life by his own way — that fundamentally one cannot learn from others.

And now my theological studies! I worked with zeal at the various theological subjects, but continued my philosophical studies as well, attending Rasmus Nielsen's evening lectures regularly, and now Brøchner's on the history of philosophy too. I took part in a *privatissimum* which Brøchner held on Kant's *Kritik der Urtheilskraft*. But from the purely philosophical side it was maintained ever more firmly that a scientific harmony between faith and knowledge was impossible — that fundamentally there was no such thing as a theological science. So I wandered back and forth between theology and philosophy — literally as well, since their lecture rooms lay at either end of the long university corridor upstairs. A constant intellectual discord asserted itself in me, over and above the personal one called forth by the new conception of Christianity.

Those were the heaviest and darkest years of my life. I shut myself up with my doubts and became unsociable and closed towards those nearest me. However much I cared for them, I was not a good member of the family. Life in my room and life in

the sitting room came to stand before me as two worlds, and I was only too poor at making the transition between them. The bright and harmonious way in which they took everything down there exasperated me. It was just in those years that increased prosperity came into the house, and people enjoyed, in their fashion, what it now gave access to. I held myself aloof and cold. I have many sins on my conscience from those years, and only later have I understood how greatly I had to be borne with. My parents were, as I have since learned, anxious about me, and asked my friends for advice.

Through all this there also worked an inclination to hypochondria, which is bound up with my bodily constitution and has followed me all my life, right up into old age. Only those closest to me have had occasion to notice this tendency, which as a rule I find it easy to force back in the presence of strangers. In my book *Den store Humor* [The Great Humour], the section dealing with hypochondria (*acedia*) is one of those most built upon self-experience. Heaviness and darkness could spread over the mind without demonstrable cause and give everything a dull and foggy appearance. For a long time there often came over me a sensation as though I were hanging by a hair which might snap at any moment. Dissatisfied with myself and with the fact that I was accomplishing nothing in the world, I often felt that everything was hopeless for me. This tendency naturally gained the upper hand all the more easily in that my mind stood doubting and restless before the greatest questions. What the balance of force was between the two currents — the one coming from bodily heaviness, the other from the weight of intellectual and personal problems — I naturally cannot disentangle, and could do so still less at the time.

But it was not, of course, that I went about perpetually as one lost. My studies occupied me greatly. Besides my professional subject, the interest in Hebrew already awakened at school led me to read Arabic with Professor van Mehren. I got so far as to read a couple of tales from the *Thousand and One Nights* in the original, and for a while I even thought of becoming an orientalist — which would probably have worked to draw me off from my absorption in philosophical and religious problems. I still read a fair amount of philosophy, and followed in particular the development from Kant to Hegel, a period which at that time especially stood in a peculiar splendour. Not only had Kierkegaard been strongly influenced by Hegel, but both Rasmus Nielsen and Brøchner represented shades of Hegelianism. I also read some dialogues of Plato's in the original. In short, my time was well filled.

[...]

Besides Valby there was another place to which I often walked out, and where I found

rest and understanding. An old uncle of mine lived at a country house in Frederiksberg Smallegade, and his house was kept by a distant relation of my parents, Sofie Pape, sister of the young girl I had visited towards the end of my Jutland journey.² In her I found the elder sister I had often wished for. She understood my interest in Kierkegaard, though she kept in the main to his religious discourses. And now, in the winter of 1863–64, her younger sister Emma came to visit her. We three came to form a little clique. But it was soon for the younger one's sake that I went there. We read together and we walked together. And I supposed now that I had acquired a sister of my own age. That it was a feeling of another kind that was stirring in me became clear to me only after her departure. For the time being I forced back everything that stirred in that direction, under the influence of the severe religious discipline I had put myself under. And yet, far more than I would admit to myself, the thought of her was in those dark years a gleam of light that kept courage and hope alive. There lay here, besides, the germ of something that later worked to bring me into a living relation to life again.

The Reckoning with Kierkegaard

I had not given up Christianity, but I made to myself the admission which Kierkegaard (in *Indøvelse i Kristendom* [Practice in Christianity]) had demanded of the representatives of the Church. I acknowledged that I was not living under the ethics which primitive Christianity presupposes or entails. I recognised my distance from the primitive Christian ideal, though I held fast that it was the ideal. I felt like a Catholic who does not enter a monastery, although he admits that this is the ideal. I held that on these terms I had the right to regard myself as a Christian, even though I could not think of becoming a clergyman.

The Church as Church could not — as I have since understood — make the admission Kierkegaard demanded. It would have amounted to admitting that it represented a wholly different religion from the primitive Christian one, once a religion and its ethics are acknowledged to belong together so closely that they stand and fall with one another. But the individual, too, who makes the admission is really conceding — and this I did not see clearly at the time either — that he does not have the religion the Church claimed to represent. It signified in reality a break with the Church, in virtue of one's own experience of life and one's own thinking, and I thereby placed myself under the principle of personality. The reach of this dawned on me only slowly and late, in

²The two sisters were daughters of the landowner H. C. Pape of Heiselt in Vendsyssel. For a time he also held a tenancy near Viborg. (See above, p. 36.)

connection with my continued experience of life and my continued studies. On this point Kierkegaard himself, in virtue of the principle that subjectivity is truth, points far out beyond himself. My love for Kierkegaard and my admiration for him have therefore been able to accompany me long after I had moved away from all dogmas. It has, to be sure, been said of me in German, on the occasion of my book on Kierkegaard, by some light-footed theologian, that I lack love for Kierkegaard and absorption in him. But the fact is that there are people who do not understand a love and an admiration which do not vent themselves in sentimental expressions, but in taking up a problem that has been posed and working at it faithfully in the way that accords with one's own personality. Kierkegaard's problem has followed me from my youth, has determined the direction of my life, has again and again led me to a more inward conception of manifold relations, to a stricter testing of myself, to a shyness of whatever lacks personal truth. And while theologians and half-theologians, in the centenary year of his birth, were whitewashing the prophet's tomb, I held to the great principle of subjectivity as truth and sought to apply it in the way that accorded with my personality and my studies.

Purely philosophically, the study of Kierkegaard led me to a thought which my later philosophical study went on to deepen and to apply in detail: namely, that the formal peculiarity of spiritual life lies in the unity, the concentration, with which the content of life is gathered together, and that the measure of the worth of a spiritual life lies in the relation between the fullness of the content and the energy of the concentration. This thought, which has appeared in the history of philosophy before Kierkegaard, underlies Kierkegaard's philosophical characterisation of the different stages or types of life. This point, naturally, was not clear to me then either. It dawned on me only through a critical study of English philosophy and through the preliminary work for my *Psykologi*.

There was another point of view from which, in those years, I was likewise not yet able to judge Kierkegaard's conception of primitive Christianity. Theologians are accustomed to regard the thought which carries the whole primitive Christian ethics — namely the expectation of the imminent arrival of "the Kingdom of Heaven" — as an inessential illusion of the earliest congregation, or else they explain away the passages where it is spoken of with particular force. And to my great astonishment I saw, when Kierkegaard's posthumous papers were printed, that he himself regarded the expectation as an illusion — only that he inverted the relation: in his view one could not live by an ethics such as the primitive Christian one without that illusion. "It is to such a degree agonising to be the true Christian that it would not be endurable if one did not constantly expect Christ's return precisely now." (*Efterladte Papirer*, 1849, p. 248.) By

calling the expectation an illusion, Kierkegaard sets himself in complete opposition to primitive Christianity. From a historical standpoint the expectation is a fact, and is the constant positive presupposition without which the ethics of the New Testament cannot be understood. I saw this clearly when later on I began my reading of the New Testament over again. Yet I had already earlier had an inkling of this connection, in that already in my student years I felt sympathy for Irvingism, which attempted to build precisely on the actual expectation (“precisely now”). In the history of religion I have since learned to see the place of the New Testament expectation within a whole series of apocalypses or prophecies within the Jewish world. — But I return to where I stood in the autumn of 1864.

Besides the reason given above for my not wanting to be a clergyman, there was also another reason, which now, as I look back, strikes me as fully as essential. I could not conceive of having to step forward at a fixed day and hour (Sunday at ten o’clock!) and speak about what was the most inward and the highest of all things to me. The moments in which anything of that kind stirred in me came as gifts I could not reckon on in advance or call forth at will. Nor was I master of my hypochondriac states, in which what had stood clear and true in the good times was suddenly darkened and seemed to be nothing. To this was added a shyness — I might as well call it a chastity — which made, and makes, me unwilling to speak of what moves me most inwardly. I have also since experienced all too often that what moved me most strongly in a quiet hour of preparation had no effect when I came out with it from a rostrum.

From Theology to Philosophy

Among my theological teachers it is Hermansen to whom I owe most, especially so far as this year is concerned. It had long since become clear to me that his hyper-orthodox interpretation of the Old Testament was untenable, and that his attempts to repel what he called “the encroachments of the newer criticism” had failed. But I continued to take an interest in reading the Old Testament in the original. I taught Hebrew myself and had, as already mentioned, also read a little Arabic. And as regards my last year of study, I owe Hermansen much for his learned and thorough going-through of the papers we wrote at the exercises he held. It was the theology of the seventeenth century that furnished the presuppositions of his expositions on the subjects we treated; but for that very reason there was a firmness and a consistency in the train of thought which modern theologians of Clausen’s and Martensen’s tendency did not offer. And then it did one

good to work something out oneself, to be a little active after so much receptivity. I still think with a certain pleasure of those Saturday afternoons when I sat in Lecture Room No. 6 and worked out my exercise papers. Hermansen himself was a solid Jutlander, naive and dryly humorous, friendly and helpful.

[...]

They were hard problems that I took with me from the period of my life which had now closed. I had preserved my personal faith, with the reservation I described earlier. But in what relation was this faith now to stand — and how could it stand — to whatever else occupied me in life? That was the chief question that followed me. And to answer it, philosophical thinking was necessary. Philosophy, which had hitherto been a secondary subject for me, now became a principal one. For the answering of that question demanded an investigation of what human knowledge is and what it can do, and in what relation it stands to personal life. I had to learn what the human life of the mind is able to reach on its own, in order then to be able to see how far a connection between it and religious faith was possible, and on what terms. That was the problem the Kierkegaard studies had confronted me with, but had not solved. I had to pursue this question further. My future I pictured to myself provisionally in this way: that teaching should be my outward occupation, with such studies attached to it as it demanded — but that I would then strive to have a closet of my own where what lay personally on my mind could be cultivated. That my philosophising might come to have any significance whatever for others did not occur to me.

And so, after the summer holidays, I began my work as a teacher. Ever since my schooldays I had been interested in historical reading, and I now planned a study of the most important historical works, from Herodotus and Thucydides to Macaulay and Ranke. I also thought for a moment of competing for a prize essay the University had announced on a subject from the Danish Middle Ages; but nothing came of it. Philosophy was pressing, and as a contrast to all the theology I had been through, I felt a need to immerse myself in Greek philosophy. As I wrote a few years later in my doctoral *vita*: “Classical antiquity came before me in a fresher and clearer light precisely by contrast with the scholastic period I seemed to myself to have lived through; I took real pleasure in reading its historians, its poets, and soon its philosophers above all. I thereby won a deep conviction of the independent significance of science and of humane life.” Here too Kierkegaard’s guidance was constantly at work. He had clearly maintained the Socratic-Platonic conception of thought and life as a power of the spirit, of which one had to give oneself an account before one could with full right and clear consciousness

come to a standpoint that was really higher. I now read the Greek philosophical works in sequence, and in the following years this became my principal study. In my teaching I exchanged, some years later, history and Danish for Latin (in the middle forms) and Greek (in the upper forms), and there came in this way a certain connection between my life at school and my life in the study. Besides Mariboe's School I also taught at the "Lyceum" and, for a short time, at "Bohr's School". I was very fond of teaching, especially in the upper forms, and here I have won friends who have shown me faithful devotion even after their schoolyears.

The Controversy over Faith and Knowledge

In the winter of 1865–66 a discussion was carried on in the press about Rasmus Nielsen's doctrine of faith and knowledge as two wholly different principles which, precisely on account of their difference, were supposed to be practically and personally reconcilable. I had been led to share this view through my own personal development in religious respects, as well as through my philosophical studies. This last requires a short explanation.

Here at home, around 1860, Hegel's philosophy was still regarded as a high point of thought. A magnificent attempt had been made there to show that, just as in the human mind a single thought is understood only by its relation to other thoughts, so in nature, in history, in the world of experience as a whole, no phenomenon and no event is isolated, but everything is bound up with everything else in the most intimate way. As the one thought proceeds from the other, so the one phenomenon of experience from the other. And Hegel held that it was possible to develop the mutual connection between thoughts in such a way that it should at the same time come to express the connection between things. From this sprang his great confidence in pure speculation. Human thought could not be something isolated in the world; its laws had to be the laws of the world.

Here at home this doctrine had been the object of searching criticism by Sibbern and Kierkegaard. The intimations these thinkers gave of a more critical and more empirical philosophy were not attended to. For the time being the position was that both science and religion, each for itself, claimed to give an absolute solution to the riddles of existence. Here it stood for Hegel in such a way that the religious representations contained, in the form of image, the same thing that philosophy set forth in the pure form of thought. Trusting in this view, many Hegelians believed themselves to be in

good agreement with the doctrine of the Church, and Rasmus Nielsen for a time was of their number. But there came a great reversal in his view under the influence of Kierkegaard's writings. He broke with his former allies, particularly Martensen, and now maintained the absolute independence of religion over against science. They now came to stand as two different worlds, and man had to live in both of them. This view was attacked from two sides. Theology continued to claim to be a science, and saw a danger in religion's being consigned to the world of the purely personal and subjective. From the opposite side it was above all Georg Brandes who came forward, in various newspaper articles and later in a small work, *Dualismen i vor nyeste Filosofi* [Dualism in Our Most Recent Philosophy]. I took part in the quarrel in a very clumsily shaped little work, *Filosofi og Teologi* [Philosophy and Theology] (1866), which was in the main a report of the discussion that had been carried on, after the appearance of Martensen's *Dogmatik* (1849), about the relation between philosophy and theology. My own relation to the whole matter I expressed some years later in my doctoral *vita* thus: "I have always conceived this view [Rasmus Nielsen's conception of faith and knowledge] more from the sceptical and negative side, more as a means to a personal solution of the difficulties, than as a positive doctrine in its own right." That is to say, I was more a Kierkegaardian than a Nielsenian. Brøchner later drew express attention to the opposition between Kierkegaard's standpoint and Nielsen's. And this opposition became (as I have shown in *Danske Filosofer*) more and more pronounced in the course of Nielsen's continued development of his thoughts, until at last (in his work *Om Aandsdannelse* [On the Formation of the Mind], 1877) he wholly disavowed Kierkegaard and in effect conceded the case to Kierkegaard's theological opponents.

For my part the matter stood thus, that I was on the way out of theology, and that what now mattered was what conception of science, and of a personal outlook on life, I could arrive at. A new period of learning now began for me. What mattered was to obtain a foundation for my further development, both in scientific and in purely personal respects. Of this, of course, I was not conscious at the time; but when I look back I find an involuntary striving after a footing. Some eight years passed before such a footing was reached. I had to learn the peculiar character of the different main problems, and thereby to understand both their connection and their independence. In a short sketch for a lecture course in the autumn of 1874 on "Introduction to Philosophy" were contained the ground-lines of everything I have since presented at greater or less length.

Prize Essay, Doctorate, and Paris

But I anticipate. — My studies in Greek philosophy gathered, at the point at which I here stand, more and more around a definite task, which I treated in a work, *Den antike Opfattelse af den menneskelige Villie* [The Ancient Conception of the Human Will], that I defended in 1870 for the doctorate in philosophy. Some years earlier I had answered the University's philosophical prize question (for 1867–68) and won the gold medal. That question, too, concerned the human will, in that it called for an investigation of the dispute about freedom of the will which was conducted in its day (1824 and following) in our literature between the forensic physician Howitz, Sibbern, A. S. Ørsted and others. I am not satisfied with the solution I intimated, and the treatise had, in the judgment of the examiners (Nielsen and Brøchner), its essential value in its searching characterisation of the various standpoints that had asserted themselves, of which those of Howitz and Sibbern especially had interested me.

From this time on I came into closer relations with Brøchner. When I had won the gold medal he advised me to travel abroad, and my father then made me a present of a journey. I wavered somewhat as to where I should go. Alongside my other work I had sought to orient myself with regard to the development of philosophy in Germany after Hegel's time, and here the Göttingen philosopher Hermann Lotze had particularly attracted my attention. I considered the possibility of studying under him at Göttingen. But I judged that I could get to know this subtle thinker and gifted writer quite as well through his books as through his lectures, and that a stay in a small German university town would not be able to enrich me in any areas beyond the purely scientific. I thought I should get a more many-sided profit from spending a winter in Paris, where not only could one study, but where art and literature and a pulsing metropolitan life offered possibilities of a more many-sided education. I spent a very rich winter in Paris (1868–69), attended lectures (among others by Taine), worked at my dissertation, was a constant visitor at museums and theatres, and used my eyes to observe life in that centre of the world. Here I came to know other directions of thought than those which stemmed from Germany and which had hitherto had the greatest influence on those at home who concerned themselves with philosophy. I became especially aware of the positivist tendency, represented partly by the great figure of Comte — beside, and in contrast to, Hegel the greatest systematic thinker of the nineteenth century — and partly by Herbert Spencer's bold but magnificent generalisation of the concept of development. It was some time, however, before this tendency came to have a more decisive significance for me. I have always been slow to turn. Thoughts had to ripen quietly in me before I could

work with them.

From the Letters of the Engagement Years

30 September 1866. — If one tries to keep life going on idyllic, contemplative harmony, one will surely come up against reality and learn that the reconciliation was only in thought or in imagination ... That is why I have become a disciple of Rasmus Nielsen: because he so strongly emphasises the opposition between faith and knowledge. They are, after all, two wholly different states of the soul. Faith is an “unaltered disposition”, but knowledge belongs to the realm of contemplation.

[...]

1 March 1867. — You said once at Christmas that I never wrote anything about my studies ... So far as I can come to clarity with myself, I am convinced that it is the one right thing I am doing when I strive after a more comprehensive and more deeply penetrating knowledge and understanding in philosophical respects. It must lead to a goal which for me personally will be of great importance; I feel so surely that my life would become unsteady and wavering if I turned these questions away and let them stand in an indeterminate fog. In that respect I harbour no doubt, although the goal of course often seems to hide itself from me, and I seem to myself so powerless and so wretched. Whether I shall succeed in reaching such a result that it should also have some significance outwardly is, on the other hand, another question. One cannot, after all, get further than one’s ability reaches. But do you not agree with me that the first consideration is the more important? (There followed a discussion of practical prospects; I imagine myself taking the doctorate, working as a teacher at a school, and one day taking over one of the private Latin schools here in town.) To become a university teacher is something that in our small country is a piece of sheer good fortune, quite apart from the demands it makes on talent and personality.

[...]

7 November 1867. — It may perhaps interest you to hear in what direction my reading is chiefly going. Since the question of faith and knowledge, which tormented me when I was studying theology and which has ever since presented itself to me anew, led me to a closer occupation with the history of philosophy, I have gradually become convinced that without having grasped Greek thought in its characteristic main forms one would

not have the right conception of what the matter really turns on. For the Greeks had attained the highest completion of spiritual development that could be reached under purely human conditions. With Christianity, faith came into the world and new forces were set in motion; but everything we have in the way of human forms of culture points back in its main features to the Greeks. For half a year now, therefore, I have been occupied with Plato and Aristotle, and if I succeed in carrying through my plan I shall one day use a subject from this field for a doctoral dissertation. Alongside this I busy myself with history and Icelandic, which I need for my teaching.

14 November 1867. — Lately I have read a good deal of Shakespeare aloud, especially on Sunday evenings, and have also — which is a great pleasure — heard Poul Kierkegaard read. About a fortnight ago he, Troels Lund and I sat here one evening and read Shakespeare until it was almost one o'clock, without our knowing it.

24 November 1867. — A change that has taken place in me this autumn consists in my no longer being able to agree with Rasmus Nielsen, to whom, as you know, I had formerly attached myself on the whole. Partly a wavering in himself, partly a striking criticism by Professor Brøchner, partly and above all a renewed testing of the matter itself (not least in conversations with Poul Kierkegaard), have shown me what is untenable in his view. Yet I have not thereby been brought closer to the ecclesiastical ... On the contrary, it has at the same time dawned on me that on several points I held opinions which had no true root in me, but stuck fast as something external and handed down. Christianity will — of this I am fully and firmly convinced — always be the highest truth for me, the one in which alone I can find the riddles of life solved. But only what I can personally experience and make my own can be truth for me; and I have come to the conviction that whatever one supposes oneself to possess beyond that rests on unconscious hypocrisy. The view whose untenability I have now come to see was of course not without significance; it was a stage of development that had to be passed through.

Privatdocent: Science and Personality

In the spring semester of 1871 I began to lecture as *privatdocent* at the University. My effort to orient myself within contemporary philosophy led to the publication of two books, *Filosofien i Tyskland efter Hegel* [Philosophy in Germany after Hegel] (1872) and *Den engelske Filosofi i vore Dage* [English Philosophy in Our Day] (1874). Through a critical testing of English philosophy, especially as represented by Mill and Spencer,

I was led to see the significance of a thought which had lain behind Kierkegaard's philosophising and had still earlier been consciously brought forward by Kant: namely the thought of the unifying, unity-seeking character of the life of human consciousness. From this I later derived the hypothesis I laid at the basis of my *Psykologi*. In the autumn of 1874 I gave a course of lectures on "Introduction to Philosophy", in which, from the standpoint thus won, I characterised the different philosophical problems. From this time onward it became gradually clear to me that it is philosophy's chief task to show how that fundamental peculiarity of the human soul displays itself in the various domains of human thought. My philosophy, if I may use the word, became a doctrine of problems — that is, of tasks determined by the interaction between the manifoldness of observations and the unity-seeking need and capacity. No closed system could come out of this. On the contrary, through new observations and new energy of thought new tasks must constantly present themselves. All that matters is to show that everything which becomes a problem for the human spirit bears that spirit's stamp and is determined by its nature, whether or not the problem can be solved once and for all. It has been a fruitful working hypothesis for me, and for over forty years I have sought to apply it to a series of questions. I have found that this point of view was satisfying not only in the intellectual respect (though people have sometimes found it too sceptical or too subjective), but that here too there was a possibility of that harmony between science and personality which I had so long sought. For personally as well, it is a matter of bringing a whole out of the manifold of experiences, impulses and thoughts that make up the content of our inner life. The sharp opposition between science and personality thereby falls away. Science is itself a personal labour, sprung from the innermost need of personality. And on the other hand there is nothing in personal life which could not be made the object of scientific consideration — at all events of historical and psychological investigation.

Given this relation between science and personality, it becomes both unnecessary and impossible to entertain any fear that science should lead to results harmful to personal life. And just as little is there ground for lyrical proclamations that there is nothing above science and nothing beside it. Science will not let itself be cowed; but it is too serious a matter to be the object of a lyricism that is not backed, point for point, by work.

For my part it became from this time on more and more clear that what was to support me in life could not be anything outside me, but had to be something that made itself known within me — in the very best and clearest thoughts I could win, in the very best and purest striving that could lay claim to me. What mattered was not a vision but

an eye that could see — a central power within me, built upon experience of life and upon the testing of thought — an inward home, a chapel built up out of everything that could give life value. The measure of truth and of value had to be drawn from our own innermost being, and it is in reality from there that science draws it, without always being conscious of the fact. Every image, every form, every concept by whose help we are able to interpret this innermost thing, which is at the same time the highest, and by which we try to make it an object for ourselves, can have only symbolic significance; and here lies the boundary between scientific thinking and poetic analogising.

Hans Brøchner

When, after this Jutland excursion, I turn back to my life in Copenhagen, there is one figure that stands out for me in my recollection of the years around 1870. It is Hans Brøchner. I had come into connection with him in the summer of 1867, when, having heard me speak as an opponent at a dissertation defence, he sent me a kind and encouraging greeting. From that time on I visited him often. I received advice from him regarding my study of the history of philosophy, and when I had written a critical review of one of his books, he sent me his counter-remarks and asked me to come one evening and discuss them with him. In the following years, until his death (1875), I visited him regularly once a month in his solitary home, where he lived as a widower with his two children. He associated with none of his contemporaries, with the exception of his friend from youth, Privy Councillor Vedel. Of the younger men, only Georg Brandes besides myself came to him, after his closest disciple, the amiable and gifted Kristian Møller, had died. When one visited him it was as a rule not philosophical subjects that came up. In his solitude he felt a desire to hear news of the academic world and of the world at large. I still see him sitting in his rocking chair, or walking up and down the floor with his characteristic long and decided strides. The unusually handsome face could then light up with goodwill and interest. Often he spoke of his travels, or of his young wife who had died early. Of Costanza, the young Italian woman he had been in love with in his youth, he never spoke to me; it was only when I published his letters that I came to know this episode of his life. In the letters it appears, as he describes it, like a novel full of feeling. It seems to have been a confessor's intervention that prevented his bringing Costanza up to the North. It would surely have been a risky experiment too. — When one rose to take one's leave, he became particularly lively and had many things to ask and to talk about; it was as though he were reluctant to let go of the few links that bound him to

the outside world.

He was a philosophical hermit. The circle of thoughts he had made his own was his spiritual home. He had not much capacity for communicating himself in free form, varying his expressions according to situations and personalities, and he had once and for all gathered his ideas into definite, very abstract forms. But both in lectures and in conversation there could come a vibration into his voice and his expression, a sign of the deep feeling that lay behind and bore witness to the connection of the thought with the whole personality. He was a knight of thought, the last representative among us of that idealism which, confident that the innermost of existence could find, and had found, expression in the form of thought, found in this same form the expression of personal life's highest aspiration. For those who came after him in the field of philosophy the problems have become more composite and more manifold. In one of his last lectures Brøchner declared himself an adherent of "the idealist philosophy which Germany has the honour of having brought forth", and there have hardly been many in whom that philosophy's chief thinker so thoroughly permeated and ennobled the personality as in him. The image of "the quiet professor", as he has been called, has followed me on my way and reminded me what value the life of thought can have, beyond the purely intellectual domain as well, when there is seriousness in the work of thought. His friendship was an honour and an encouragement to me, and it was with deep emotion that I took leave of him on his deathbed. It was the day before he died that I saw him for the last time. He spoke with complete calm about his departure, and settled various matters with me. When he bade me farewell and thanked me for my friendship, I was more overcome than he. His housekeeper afterwards related that he had said quite calmly, when I had gone: "Take that glass away, for Dr Høffding's tears are in it."

A little myth formed itself, when he was dead, about his last moments. He died on 17 December (1875) towards the afternoon — that is, in the darkest season. One of the last things he said was: "We must have light in here." In the period immediately after his death I heard from several quarters that he was supposed to have cried out for light, and there were those who added that it was no wonder that *that* man cried out for light! — The myth seems, however, to have died a natural death. For a time it took some nourishment from what happened at his funeral. There was at that time no possibility of a purely civil burial. He had wished to be buried from the University, and that a colleague should speak; but if that could not be done, he had named a particular clergyman who had spoken over his young friend Kristian Møller and had on that occasion shown much tact. But the clergyman in question seems to have misunderstood the situation and

read more into the deceased's very conditional wish than was warranted. I thought of correcting the misunderstanding, but gave it up when Brøchner's oldest friend, Privy Councillor Vedel, firmly advised against it.

In the preface to my edition of the correspondence of Brøchner and Molbech, and in *Danske Filosofer*, I have given a characterisation of Brøchner as a personality and as a thinker; and my work *Den nyere Filosofis Historie* [The History of Modern Philosophy] I have dedicated "to the memory of my teacher and friend".

The Circle of Friends in Copenhagen

In Copenhagen we associated first and foremost with Julius Petersen and his wife Oliva, née Munch. He now practised in Nørrebro and quickly acquired a large practice, not least in the poor quarters. He was restlessly active, and had already begun his studies in the history of medicine. When he came home from sick-visits in poor homes he could be indignant at the luxury he thought he saw in their very modest dwellings, and he could sit sunk in dejection and discontent. But suddenly a quite different mood could come over him, and often, when we thought the barometer was low, there would come an invitation to take part in a little party. Against his restlessness and his many swings there was good use for Oliva's level-headedness, clear understanding and firm will. As the flock of children quickly grew, there was enough for her to do. And she always kept her house running well, so that it even became a gathering place for his friends. Here we met with Kristian Arentzen, Viggo Hørup and Holger Drachmann and their wives, and in many long speeches at the festive supper table the many questions of the time were discussed. — Troels Lund I had made the acquaintance of in my student years. From philology he had gone over to theology, and after his examination he took up, as I did, studies in Greek philosophy, and defended (1871) an interesting dissertation on Socrates. Later he went over to historical studies, occasioned by an appointment at the National Archives (the Privy Archives, as it was then called). Troels Lund's fine, harmonious personality was a pleasure to be with, and he and his lively wife made their home a place we gladly came to. And in those days one could also have the pleasure of being surprised by a visit; it was so agreeable when Lund and his wife came and settled in for the evening, making do with whatever the house could provide. — Heegaard's home, too, calls up many good recollections. He was an opponent at my doctoral defence, and from that time we came to stand close to one another. Having broken with Rasmus Nielsen, he remained in a searching state, absorbed in eager study of Kant and of the

newer English philosophers; he also occupied himself a great deal with mathematics. As his financial circumstances were straitened, he had to take on exhausting extra work. Among other things he wrote anonymously a series of novels in which he was strongly influenced by Dickens. For some years they found quite a large readership. He also took on office work for a publisher for a time. Heegaard was, in his vigorous period, open and jovial, full of mockery for dogmatists of every kind; the clergy he liked to call bonzes. He perhaps declaimed a little too much against dogmatism instead of immersing himself actively in positive work. But it was fruitful and encouraging to be in his company. And in his home his wife had a refreshing effect by her clear and cheerful bearing in the most various circumstances.

Georg Brandes

Georg Brandes and I had been opponents in the controversy over faith and knowledge. Later we often met at the house of Troels Lund's father. When he and his brother had founded the journal *Det nittende Aarhundrede* [The Nineteenth Century], I became a contributor and thereby came into a closer and, for me, very beneficial connection with him.

He invited me one evening after he had married, and he and his wife also visited my home. I have always followed him with admiration in his works of literary criticism. He has, for me as for so many others, opened new poetic and literary worlds, and by his capacity for searching characterisation and analysis he has cast light on so many of literature's great figures. I felt myself very different from him in temperament. I took everything more heavily and more awkwardly, and I lacked the self-confidence which is the condition of bold action. What I have been able to accomplish is owing to long and untiring work, and my tasks lay further from the great public. Besides, I have generally held the view that whatever is to be altered or cleared out of the way in the world of thought or of society can first be recognised once the right thing has been found. It is difficult to find the right thing, but when it is found it becomes clear what the false is. And the forms in which men's need for support and anchorage in life comes to rest can be altered only when that need itself is altered; but such alteration takes place very slowly, if it is to be thorough. Here too it is truth that shows what is false, positivity that grounds negativity. As Spinoza says: truth is the sign both of itself and of falsity (*verum est index sui et falsi*). And Comte maintained that one displaces only what one replaces. This way of looking at things meant that I stood differently towards religious

and moral polemic than Brandes did. But his criticism has in many ways benefited my own activity, in that it awakened in many people a need for a further orientation in the domain of thought. I have certainly seen, in not a few cases, how the view arose that it was enough to have brisk and reckless opinions, without one's needing to mind that philosophy demanded a searching investigation.

What I am not least grateful to Brandes for, from the time I am speaking of here, the seventies, is the advice he gave me on the occasion of the contributions I sent to his journal. Thus he wrote to me on 7 June 1875: "Allow me, not so much as editor as in the capacity of a sympathetic fellow-labourer, to put a couple of questions to you. Have you ever made the experiment of reading what you send to press aloud to some man who has not attended a learned school? Have you read it aloud to a lady who was not particularly schooled in philosophy? Have you put a mark against the passages he or she did not understand, and tried to rewrite them in other words? I venture to say that you have not made this attempt. But why not?" And then he complains particularly of a passage in an article I had submitted to the journal, which was undeniably expressed in a very unpopular way. I found the complaint just; unfortunately it probably also strikes much of what I have written since, although I really did set myself to write as accessibly as possible. But there is, after all, a difference between philosophy and literary history; and besides, it has been my lot to develop slowly and to come late to clarity. I could have waited to write until everything could be expressed clearly (if not for those who have no presuppositions at all); that would perhaps have been no loss to literature. But I have myself always learned much by attempting to present my thoughts and the knowledge I had so far acquired. And I had in Brøchner an example of what it can lead to when one waits too long before writing; he often lamented that he had wanted to wait with his compositions until he had completely worked through all his subjects, and when that time seemed to him to have come he was nearly fifty, and had lived himself wholly into the abstract expressions handed down from Hegelian philosophy, which in themselves might have done good service as short formulas for his solitary thinking. — Yet I have often since been surprised at how wide the circles are that many of my books have reached.

When in 1876 I had published my little book *Om Grundlaget for den humane Etik* [On the Foundation of Humane Ethics], to which I shall return in another connection, Brandes wrote to me (24 October 1876): "You are, though on another foundation, the 'transfigured' Brøchner, and it would certainly have been a great joy to Brøchner had he lived to see this book of yours. ... I congratulate you also on the form of your book. You

have gained extraordinarily here in freedom and mobility. You once said a despondent word to me about dryness in your style, in which you were far too severe with yourself. ... There is in my opinion still too little temperament in your style; you do not yet write sufficiently with your whole personality, the whole man. But you are on the way to doing so.” — For the rest, Brandes recalls in this letter the inscription on the papers of the Committee of Public Safety: “Liberté, Égalité, Fraternité, ou la mort!” — and he thinks that I can hardly ever have been young enough to say this. In that he is quite right. Yet it jarred a little on my ears when he added: “You must have been born to a certain degree old.” Of himself he then says: “I am afraid that I was once very young.” —

The relation into which I had come with Brandes was a source of much joy and encouragement to me. After Brøchner’s death I felt lonely, and since Brandes united with his great artistic sense an understanding of philosophical investigations, his letters were always welcome to me. Some years later he wrote to me from Berlin: “I am very glad to stand on such friendly terms with you; there is nothing I would rather do than live in brotherly understanding with all my contemporaries in the North who inquire honestly.” What was here so warmly expressed found a complete echo on my side. And this feeling did not disappear in me even when, a good many years later, it was put to the test by a serious and sharp opposition between our views on an essential point.